

in his own right. Around the time when I moved on to head investment banking, he was head of marketing at a large corporate MNC. But his real desire was to work in the not-for-profit sector, and we both decided it would be our joint way of giving back to society.

And as both of us couldn't do it, he was going to do it for the two of us. And, he really succeeded there in his work with SEWA [Self Employed Women's Association] as CEO of the Grassroots Trading Network. What he established there, even today [Founder] Ela Bhatt and Reema Nanavati [who leads it now] and others at SEWA remember him very, very fondly. And, those achievements helped me and guided me in my own entry into the not-for-profit spaces, because I learnt through him, the DNA of the not-for-profit sector.

The suspicions, the issues, the inability of the not-for-profit sector and corporates to work comfortably with each other, which was really the path which

“A lot of the work in the NGO world is fraught with frustration. It's slower than what I'm used to in the corporate world. The funds are not easy to come by”

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Rashid, my husband, had embarked on, to try and get corporates and NGOs to work together. He got companies like HUL, ITC working with SEWA in a way where revenue models went up from ₹10-20 lakh to a crore. Earlier, it tended to be much more about corporates signing cheques to NGOs, never about helping them scale up to grow, to demonstrate partnership. Now, when a Fabindia comes together with SEWA, it helps SEWA make products that can retail through Fabindia, but it has to spend a lot of energy and time, leading to frustration on timelines not being met, products not being right. So, that patience, that DNA at the corporate level is very important. Just like ITC taught them how to package spices that clears customs so that they could then achieve 10 times the price they were getting by selling in the local market; or Unilever, which helped them retail a brand called Rudy, which sold in the Tata retail stores, with Noel Tata himself actively engaged with the joint venture. These are some of the things we have to see a lot more of, as the best partnerships are the ones that have corporates, government, and not-for-profit as implementers, all working together.

Q: Having worked in this field of water and sanitation, do you get the sense that large Indian corporations are actually sensitive to the problems of climate change? Or is it mostly lip service, with them not taking it as seriously as they should?

A: You specifically said large companies; I think they get it. They're getting pressure from the investors, sometimes from their banks, too, but not enough. [There's] certainly [pressure] from foreign investors and foreign banks. The issue is really much bigger when we look at the MSME world. And, I think there, we need to really look at corporate parks, where the provision of these services is happening at a global climate-sensitive stance—energy as renewable energy or circularity of water being addressed, etc. So, it's a provision of infrastructure service, for which the MSMEs in that park pay, as it is very difficult for each small company to try and plan and have a programme for themselves. Getting them to pay for it is the answer rather than getting each to do it for themselves. The danger then is that sometimes it becomes a tick-box exercise where they say they have it, but we see often that a sanitation facility constructed by a real estate company—because it's mandatory—has fallen apart six months later.

Whereas here, in the model that I would like to see, because someone's paying for it, the provision of that service is going to be operational because the companies drawing on that service are going to ask the provider of the service 'why have you not done what you should have done?' This has a much better chance of working.

Q: Finally, I want to ask you about the issue of independent directorships, as you sit on so many boards. When this whole NSE-Chitra Ramkrishna [row] came into the open, the point was made that if the board was strong enough, it may have been spotted earlier. Do you believe independent directors can actually prevent such episodes?

A: You know, the one shortcoming that you have as an independent director is you only get to hear and see what the management presents to you. But yes, to the extent that you're engaged in the community and the stock market, the gossip vine can pick up and signal on what is happening, maybe then you can question the company about what is happening in a particular space. But you can easily be blindsided by a management that chooses not to bring certain things out in the open.